

Security in Cable Space

Are you more prone to security breaches if you are on a cable modem network or DSL network? Conventional logic would seem to think so. While cable modems and DSL still assign you a dynamic IP address, the fact of the matter is that because you are in the 'always on' state, you have the same IP address for a longer duration of time. This gives a person who wishes to gain access to your machine more time to work towards it. Again, if you are sharing a cable modem, as most people are prone to, then your machine is on the same network as the others you are sharing the cable modem with, and it's possible that they can gain access to any shared folders that you might have. Apart from the general precautions that are valid for all computer users, as a cable modem/DSL user you should also take the simple precaution of logging off the cable/DSL connection when you are not using the Internet.

Performance Parameters

Firewall	Port scanning	Intrusion detection	Script protection	Trojan Detection
BlackICE Defender	✓	✓	✗	✓
eSafe Desktop	Partial	Blue screen	Yes (through concept of sandboxes)	✓
McAfee Personal Firewall	✓	✓	✗	✓
NeoWatch	✓	Highly unstable	✗	Partial
Norton Personal Firewall 2001	✓	Slightly unstable	Partial	Partial
PGP Desktop Security	✓	✓	✗	Partial
Sygate Personal Firewall	✓	Blue screen	✗	✓
Tiny Personal Firewall	✓	Blue screen	✗	✓
ZoneAlarm	✓	Slightly unstable	✗	Partial
ZoneAlarm Pro	✓	✓	✗	✓

that can just work out of the box.

Filtering capabilities

Since filtering is the mainstay of all firewalls, there were a number of parameters on which we tested the filtering capabilities of the firewall.

Preset security levels: All firewalls normally start off with prescribing different security levels that you can use. These levels normally range from low, or not blocking any traffic, to medium and high security. With the highest security, you are normally off the network and will not be able to connect to the Internet. Depending on the firewall, you might have three to four preset levels. These are a good aid for a new user who is not familiar with the network protocols or ports.

However, if you want to understand exactly what these presets do, you aren't in luck. Most firewalls don't give any information on the ports or protocols that are blocked, and you can just forget about customising the preset levels. Two firewalls stand out in this respect—PGP Desktop and ZoneAlarm Pro. Both of them offer a description of the protocols that are being blocked and even allow you to customise the settings. PGP's settings are based on whether your computer acts as a client or a server, while ZoneAlarm Pro allows you to have different customised (or preset) settings for the local zone (your LAN) and the Internet zone.

Blocking ports and protocols: Very few firewalls just block a port—they usually combine it with specific protocols that have to be blocked on that port. Norton has a comprehensive feature as far as granting permissions for different protocols are concerned. You can even specify the services that will be allowed on those protocols and, if you desire, the range of addresses that can use these protocols. Norton also monitors specific HTTP